

Alexander Porto

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EDUCATION

- Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)** 2022–present
Ph.D. Clinical Psychology
Anticipated Graduation: Dec. 2027/May 2028
Dissertation: *Foundational Properties of Communicative Systems*
Committee: Alex Kranjec, Ph.D., Christine Cuskley, Ph.D., Marcus Perlman, Ph.D., Elizabeth Nickrenz, Ph.D.
Pittsburgh, PA, USA
- Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)** 2022–2023
M.A. Clinical Psychology
Pittsburgh, PA, USA
- Universität Leipzig** 2018–2020
M.Sc. Early Childhood Research (Focus: Developmental Psychology & Cognitive Anthropology)
Thesis: *A Critical Theory of Childhood Research*
Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Kristina Musholt, Prof. Dr. Patricia Kanngießer
Leipzig, Germany
- Point Park University** 2011–2015
B.A. Psychology
Thesis: *Phenomenological Responses to Architectural Environments*
Pittsburgh, PA, USA

ACADEMIC POSITIONS & EMPLOYMENT

- Universität Leipzig**
Predoctoral Research Fellow 2021–2022
Project: The Production of Symbolic Communication During Language Acquisition
- Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology (Dept. Comparative Cultural Psychology)**
Guest Researcher 2021–2022
Project: The Production of Symbolic Communication During Language Acquisition
- Universität Leipzig**
Graduate Research Assistant 2019–2020
Project: Emotions & Social Cognition
Supervisor: Prof. Dr. Robert Hepach
- Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology (Dept. Comparative Cultural Psychology)**
Research Internship 2019–2020
Project: Social Learning in Austronesian Cultures
Supervisors: Dr. Roman Stengelin, Dr. Sarah Peoples

PSYCHOTHERAPY & COMMUNITY PSYCHOLOGY

- Doctoral Practicum** Aug. 2025–May 2026
Carnegie Mellon University, Counseling and Psychological Services (CaPS)
Pittsburgh, PA
Clinical Supervisors: Stella Yan, Ph.D., Shane Chaplin, Ph.D., Grace Wei, Ph.D., NCC
- Doctoral Practicum** Jan. 2022–May 2026
Duquesne University, Rita M. McGinley Psychology Clinic
Pittsburgh, PA
Clinical Supervisors: Kevin Smith, Ph.D., Liz Pienkos, Ph.D., Lori Koelsch, Ph.D., Jessie Goicoechea, Ph.D.
- Community-Based Psychology Fellow** 2022–2023
Duquesne University
Pittsburgh, PA

PUBLICATIONS

Porto, A., Huckle, N., Basalyga, A., Santiago, J., Kranjec., A. (2025). Glyph Norming: Human and Computational Measurements of Shape Angularity in Writing Systems. *Behavior Research Methods*. <https://doi.org/10.3758/s13428-025-02682-7>

Porto, A., Basalyga, A., Huckle, N., Santiago, J., Fein, E., Kranjec., A. (2024). Sound Symbolism Across Diverse Writing Systems. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*. <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3xc6659p>.

Brar, P., Pienkos, L., **Porto, A.**, Wood, H., Sarpal, D., Schreiber, J., Kalarchian, M., Kranjec, A. (2024). Methods and Models for Investigating Anomalous Experiences in Schizophrenia Spectrum Disorders. *Philosophical Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09515089.2024.2305232>.

Contributions: Wrote section on network modeling; general consulting on manuscript development

Porto, A. (under review: revisions submitted; draft available by request). Probabilistic claiming as meta-comparative practice.

Porto, A. (under review: revisions submitted; draft available by request). Inference, Language, Situated Conceptualization.

Porto, A. (under review; draft available by request). Naturalizing Negation.

Porto, A. (2023). A Picture Theory of Symbolic Development in Early Childhood. *Theory & Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/09593543231192973>

Porto, A., Anderson, L., Kalinich, T., Deane, K. C., Vogel, L. C., Zebracki, K. (2019). Understanding transition for youth with spinal cord injury: Youth and caregiver perceptions. *The Journal of Spinal Cord Medicine*, 1-7. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10790268.2019.1574437>

PUBLICATIONS IN PREPARATION

Porto, A., Huckle, N., Basalyga, A., Cuskley, C., Perlman, M., Kranjec., A. (in preparation). Sound-Form Iconicity in Spontaneously Produced Drawings.

Status: Data collected; data analyzed; manuscript in development; abstract and data available by request.

Porto, A. Kranjec, A. (in preparation). Novel Verbs Outperform Nouns in Artificial Language Learning.

Status: Data collected; data analyzed; manuscript in development; abstract and data available by request.

Porto, A., Pietschmann, J., Seiberth, L.C. (in preparation). Experimental Reanimation: Jumblese, Picturing, and Representational Systems.

Status: Data collected; data analyzed; manuscript written; three workshop presentations given; in informal peer review; abstract and data available by request.

Porto, A., Pietschmann, J., Seiberth, L.C. (in preparation). Jumblese, Picturing, and Representational Systems.

Status: Philosophical scoping review complete; manuscript written; two colloquium presentations; in informal peer review; abstract available by request.

CONFERENCE, WORKSHOP & COLLOQUIUM PRESENTATIONS

(†) *invited*

(*) *refereed*

Porto, A. (2025, October). *Interlocutor: Rules, Functions & Categories—A Workshop on Wilfrid Sellars*[†] [Invited Respondent]. Universität Paderborn.

Porto, A., Pietschmann, J., Seiberth, L. C. (2025, April). *Jumblese, picturing, and representational systems*[†] [Invited presentation]. CO Haag—Universität Potsdam.

Porto, A., Tilak, S., Pangaro, P., Glassman, M. (2025, August). *A lexical analysis of essays written using the ThoughtShuffler and Google search interfaces** [Conference presentation]. American Psychological Association Annual Convention.

Porto, A. (2025, January). *Naturalizing negation*[†] [Invited conference presentation]. Wittgenstein & the Formal Sciences IV, UNESCO World Logic Day.

Porto, A. (2024, December). *Naturalizing negation: Responding to the threefold puzzle of negation* [Colloquium]. Young Network for Wittgensteinian Philosophy.

Porto, A. (2024, July). *Sound symbolism across diverse writing systems** [Conference presentation]. 46th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society.

- Porto, A. (2024, June). *Sound symbolism across diverse writing systems** [Conference presentation]. IMPRS 4th Conference on Interdisciplinary Approaches to the Language Sciences, International Max Planck School for Language Sciences.
- Porto, A. (2024, May). *Sound symbolism across diverse writing systems** [Conference presentation accepted]. The Developing Communicators Conference 2024, University of Oslo.
- Porto, A. (2024, May). *Sound symbolism across diverse writing systems** [Conference presentation accepted]. 15th Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science: Memory, Space, Language, Center for Advanced Studies of Dubrovnik, Croatia.
- Porto, A. (2024, May). *The picture theory of symbolic development in early childhood** [Conference presentation accepted]. 15th Dubrovnik Conference on Cognitive Science: Memory, Space, Language, Center for Advanced Studies of Dubrovnik, Croatia.
- Porto, A. (2024, May). *Positive and negative predication: Distinction through unity** [Conference presentation]. Joint Meeting of the Interdisciplinary Coalition for North American Phenomenologists & The Society of Phenomenology and the Human Sciences, Duquesne University.
- Porto, A. (2024, April). *The picture theory of symbolic development in early childhood** [Conference presentation]. Midwinter Meeting of the Society for Theoretical and Philosophical Psychology, Duquesne University.
- Porto, A., Flynn, C., Dall'Aglia, J. (2024, April). *Drawing connections: Ideas and applications of expressive activity in the clinic* [Conference Presentation]. Midwinter Meeting of the Society for Theoretical and Philosophical Psychology, Duquesne University.
- Porto, A. (2024, April). *The picture theory of symbolic development in early childhood** [Conference presentation]. Conference of Multimodality in Early Interactions for ECRs, University of Warwick.
- Porto, A. (2022, October). *Reified childhood: Social reification during child development** [Conference presentation]. Emory Symposium for Psychoanalysis & Politics, Emory University.
- Porto, A., Anderson, L., Zebracki, K., Deane, K., Vogel, L. (2018, June). *Barriers in accessing adult healthcare for transitioning youth with spinal cord injury** [Conference presentation]. 57th Annual Scientific Meeting of the International Spinal Cord Society.
- Porto, A., Anderson, L., Zebracki, K., Deane, K., Vogel, L. (2018, May). *Barriers in accessing adult healthcare for transitioning youth with spinal cord injury** [Conference presentation]. 72nd Annual Meeting of the American Academy for Cerebral Palsy and Developmental Medicine.
- Porto, A. (2015, April). *Phenomenological responses to architectural environments* [Conference presentation]. Eighth Annual Meeting of the Society for Humanistic Psychology (APA Division 32).

TEACHING

Statistics for the Psychological Sciences

Spring 2025

Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)

Description: Designed new course for the department using R programming and open-source textbooks to create an undergraduate-appropriate intro to statistical programming for psychology; developed syllabus; delivered lectures; administered and graded portfolio exams.

Research Methods in Psychology

Fall 2024, Fall 2025, Spring 2026

Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)

Description: Developed syllabus; delivered lectures; administered exams; graded coursework; provided undergraduate research mentorship.

Introduction to Psychology

Fall 2023, Spring 2024

Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)

Description: Developed syllabus; delivered lectures; administered exams; graded coursework.

Psychological Disorders (Teaching Assistant)

Spring 2023

Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)

Supervisor: Russ Walsh, Ph.D.

Description: Graded coursework and exams.

Laboratory in Psychology (Teaching Assistant)

Fall 2022

Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology)

Supervisor: Alex Kranjec, Ph.D.

Description: Provided undergraduate research mentorship; graded coursework.

AWARDS, FUNDING & HONORS

Graduate Student Award for Excellence in Teaching Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology) Honorarium: \$250.00	2025–2026
Graduate Assistantship Duquesne University (Dept. Psychology) Honorarium: \$68,000.00	2022–2026
Pre-Doctoral Fellowship Award Universität Leipzig Research funding: 15,600.00€	2021–2022
Full Scholarship Capra Course: The Systems View of Life (Schumacher College & Fritjof Capra)	2019–2020

SOCIETY MEMBERSHIP & ADDITIONAL SCIENTIFIC ACTIVITY

Academic Consultant <i>Laboratory for Cybernetics</i> Carnegie Mellon University, School of Architecture	2025–present
Organizing Member #NewMacy In-Person Meetings Carnegie Mellon University, School of Architecture <i>jointly organized with Paul Pangaro</i>	2024–2025
Visiting Student University of Pittsburgh (Dept. Philosophy) <i>Sellars as a Metaphysician: Norms and Nature, Appearance and Reality</i> Invited by Robert Brandom, Ph.D.	Fall 2023
Full Member	Young Network for Wittgensteinian Philosophy
Student Member	Cognitive Science Society
Full Member	American Society for Cybernetics
Reviewer	Journal of Humanistic Psychology
Reviewer	Topics in Spinal Cord Injury Rehabilitation

COMPETENCIES & LANGUAGES

- **Research Methods:** Experimental Design, Mixed-Methods Research, Computational Modeling, Data Analysis (Bayesian and Frequentist), Philosophical Analysis, Literature Review, Manuscript Development
- **Programming:** R, Python (PyGaze, PsychoPy, Pygame), jsPsych, SPSS, Pure Data, OpenPose, GitHub, OpenMusic, Jupyter Notebooks, ChuckK, lab.js, HTML, Qualtrics, L^AT_EX
- **Psychological Assessment:** MMPI-2, PAI, CCAPS, BDI/BDI-Y, BAI/BAI-Y, HAM-A, GAD-7, WISC-V, NEO PI-R/FFI, TAT SCORS-G System, Rorschach R-PAS, Sentence Completion, Bender-Gestalt, OQ-45
- **Therapeutic Modalities:** Phenomenological Psychotherapy, Intensive Short-Term Dynamic Psychotherapy, MBCT/CBT, DBT, Systemic Therapy
- **Supervision & Training:** Undergraduate Research Mentorship, Master's Student Supervision, Peer Consultation, Group Peer Consultation
- **Languages:** English (Native Language), German (CEFR C1), French (CEFR A2–B1)

ACTIVE RESEARCH

Dissertation Research: Foundational Properties of Communicative Systems

Committee: Alex Kranjec, Ph.D., Christine Cuskley, Ph.D., Marcus Perlman, Ph.D., Elizabeth Nickrenz, Ph.D.

Academic Status: Proposal Approved Spring 2025

Publication Status: Studies 1 and 2 have been published.

Time-frame: Aug. 2023–present (defense anticipated Spring 2027)

Brief Abstract: I provide a framework for experimentally reconstructing the evolution of language. I open the dissertation by building a bridge between cognitive linguistics and key movements in the history of philosophy of language. In five experiments, I then validate this bridge using state-of-the-art, cross-methodological techniques from computational cognitive science, linguistics, and philosophical analysis. ([Link to description](#))

Research Practicum: Situated Phenomenological Psychopathology

Supervisor: Liz Pienkos, Ph.D.

Time-frame: Aug. 2025–Dec. 2026

Note: Research independently developed and designed

Description: Philosophical research studying psychopathology from the point of view of phenomenology, embodied social cognition, and philosophy of language.

Anticipated Outcome: Manuscript submitted for publication (1 Feb. 2026)

Independent Research: Where does vision go? Folk Psychological Conceptualizations of the Sense Modalities

Co-PI: Alex Kranjec, Ph.D.

Time-frame: July 2025–May 2026

Description: Experimental multi-method (behavioral and eye-tracking) research studying how people think about the sense modalities.

Anticipated Outcome: Manuscript submitted for publication (1 Feb. 2026)

COLLABORATIVE RELATIONSHIPS

Alexander Kranjec

Christine Cuskley

Marcus Perlman

Luz Christopher Seiberth

Julio Santiago

Robert Hepach

Alexander Basalyga

Nikolai Huckle

Joost Pietschmann

Paul Pangaro

Liz Pienkos

Shantanu Tilak

REFERENCES

Dr. Alexander Kranjec

Department of Psychology, Duquesne University

email: kranjeca@duq.edu

Dr. Liz Pienkos

Department of Psychology, Duquesne University

email: pienkose@duq.edu

Prof. Dr. Kristina Musholt

Department of Philosophy (Chair of Cognitive Anthropology), Leipzig University

email: kristina.musholt@uni-leipzig.de

Prof. Dr. Patricia Kanngießer

School of Psychology, University of Plymouth

email: patricia.kanngiesser@plymouth.ac.uk

Prof. Dr. Robert Hepach

Oxford Department of Experimental Psychology, University of Oxford

email: robert.hepach@psy.ox.ac.uk